the Israel Democracy Institute. “Because of the unstable nature of our coalition politics, the level of fragmentation, these processes have started earlier and earlier.”

This was President Rivlin’s theme when he took the stage at the annual Herzliya conference in June, two-and-a-half months after the vote. The previous gathering had featured the spat between Lapid and Bennett, and was quickly overshadowed by a bloody summer. Rivlin would steal the stage in 2015. “In the 1990s… Israeli society comprised a clear and firm majority, with minority groups alongside it,” he began. “A large secular Zionist majority, and beside it three minority groups: a national-religious minority, an Arab minority, and a *haredi* minority. Although this pattern remains frozen in the minds of much of the Israeli public, in the press, in the political system, all the while, the reality has totally changed.”

There were twelve tribes of Israel in antiquity. Today there are four, the groups Rivlin mentioned above. And none of them can claim a majority. He illustrated this point with two simple pie charts. In 1990, 52 per cent of elementary school students were enrolled in *mamlachti* schools—secular state-run institutions. The other 48 per cent was divided between state-run religious (16 per cent) *haredi* (9 per cent and Arab (23 per cent) schools. By 2018, he projected, just 38 per cent of pupils would be studying in the *mamlachti* schools. Ultra-Orthodox enrollment would jump to 22 per cent, while Arab schools would experience slight growth to 25 per cent. The religious schools would remain nearly flat, at 15 per cent.

Israeli society has many other divides, of course. Jews are split between Ashkenazi, Mizrahi, Ethiopian, Russian; Arabs, between Muslim, Christian and Druze. Everyone is divided along political and socioeconomic lines. But these four “tribes” are separated by the deepest chasms. Their children attend different schools. They consume different media. Only two of the four groups regularly serve in the army. “In the past, the IDF served as a central tool for fashioning the Israeli character,” Rivlin said. “However, in the emerging Israeli order, more than half of the population does not serve in the military.” To a large extent, they are even divided by geography, with the ultra-Orthodox cloistered in homogeneous communities and “acceptance committees” in hundreds of towns and *kibbutzim*.

Academics and analysts had been making these points for years. Rivlin was the first Israeli politician to express them so clearly, and in such a high-profile forum. In hindsight, his speech was a warning, one that has gone